2 LOSS OF DIRECTION

If more gently than Orpheus
who moved even the trees
you were to pluck the zither
the life-blood would not return
to the vain shadow . . .
Harsh fate,
but its burden becomes lighter
to bear, since everything
that attempts to turn back
is impossible. (I, 24)

WHERE DOES THE ETERNAL CURRENT COME FROM?

Clocks may well run at different speeds in the mountains and in the plains, but is this really what concerns us, ultimately, about time? In a river, the water flows more slowly near its banks, faster in the middle—but it is still flowing. . . . Is time not also something that always flows—from the past to the future? Let's leave aside the precise measurement of *how much* time passes that we wrestled with in the preceding chapter: the *numbers* by which time is measured. There's another, more essential aspect to time: its passage, its flow, the *eternal current* of the first of Rilke's *Duino Elegies*:

The eternal current
Draws all the ages along with it
Through both realms,
Overwhelming them in both.[9]

Past and future are different from each other. Cause precedes effect. Pain comes after a wound, not before it. The glass shatters into a thousand pieces, and the pieces do not re-form into a glass. We cannot change the past; we can have regrets, remorse, memories. The future instead is uncertainty, desire, anxiety, open space, destiny, perhaps. We can live toward it, shape it, because it does not yet exist. Everything is still possible. . . . Time is not a line with two equal directions: it is an arrow with different extremities.